

Author Me Good

Fun with Sophie – the poor man's answer to Adobe Acrobat, and a little more

Nimish Chandiramani

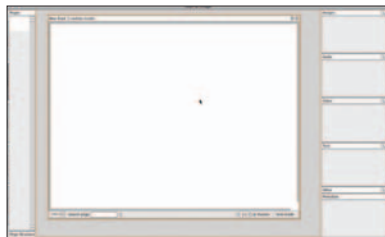
You've probably heard of the concept of the paperless office. Or the paperless school. Or the paperless university. And, of course, Rich Media. All desirable buzzwords, but they all come at a price – Acrobat, or in extreme cases, Flash.

Naturally, there's an open source alternative. It's called Sophie, and it's been developed for the Institute for the Future of the Book (which really exists), so you can probably guess at its purpose. It lets you create "books", complete with images and videos. And because it supports comments and sticky notes, it's great for group presentations.

You can download it from <http://www.sophieproject.org>, and it comes for Windows, Linux and Mac OS X.

Getting Around

Like so many open source projects, Sophie's interface isn't particularly intuitive. The screen is divided into a central area for your documents, and "flaps" on the left and right. Each flap has tabs on the side, which give you access to the program's features.

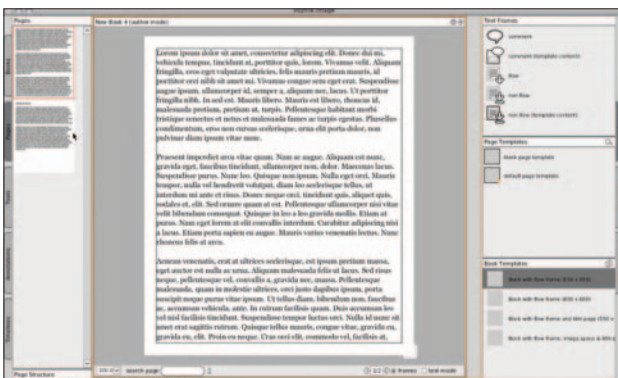


Once you get used to the interface, using Sophie is like using PowerPoint

Starting Your First Book

This is really as simple as File > New Book, but if you're going to create a book with a lot of text, we recommend using one of the templates. Select the Components tab on the right, and under Book Templates, double-click on Book with flow frame. This lets you create a new page every time text goes beyond the limits of the text box on your first page.

Now that you've got your first page ready, you can double-click inside the grey frame (the flow frame we just mentioned) to start typing in it. You can also import text into Sophie, though



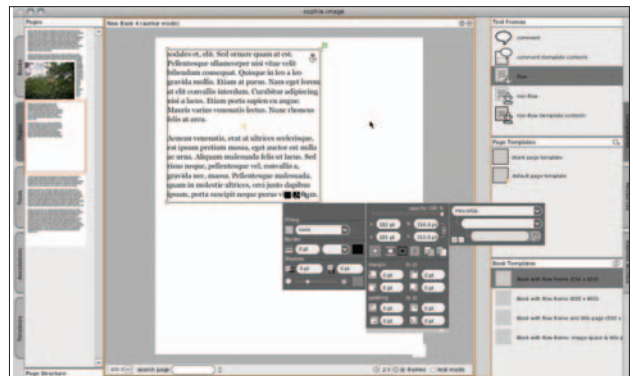
Flow frames let you deal with "overflowing" text

in true I'm-open-source-so-I-don't-go-near-Microsoft-technologies fashion, you can't import .doc files – the files in question must be in the RTF or TXT format. You can, of course, copy and paste text from anywhere.

If your cursor is in a text box long enough, you'll notice two grey buttons hovering near the box. These are halos – click on them, and you'll see HUDs (Heads-Up Displays), which let you choose fonts and paragraph styles for your text. In general, whenever you select an item in Sophie, you'll see a set of halos that open HUDs, which in turn let you change settings for that item. It's a handy feature, and prevents you from having to muck about with a bunch of palettes or dialogue boxes.

Finally, when you want to resize the frame or move it around, click on the grey border of the frame, and you'll see a "halo" – an orange dotted line around the frame (this part can be a bit frustrating, because you have to click in just the right place). Use the corners to resize the frame, and the "+" in the centre to move it around. You'll also see a new set of halos for the frame – change the background colour, margins, and actions, which we will come to in a bit.

And now, on to more complex matters.



Every object has its halo, and its own special set of HUDs

Enriching Your Book

Now that you can make your way around the interface, you can start adding media to your book. Sophie supports nearly all popular image, audio and video formats, so you don't need to worry about this, at least. Like any other such tool, you first need to import your media files into the program before using them in your book. Choose File > Import File to start importing media files. If you want to import a bunch of files, however, a better idea would be to put all these files into a folder and import them: select the Resources tab on the right, and drag your folder on to it. In just a bit, you'll see all your files getting added to the resources for the book.

To add an image to your book, just drag it on to the page. You'll be able to use the HUDs to change the size of the image, add a background colour, and choose how text wraps around it. If you don't have media to import, fret not. Select the Internet Archive tab on the right, and you'll be able to search for royalty-free images, music or video to add to your book.